

Session 19: Lavan Pursues Jacob

Key Takeaways

- Both Yaaqov and Lavan deceive each other and then proclaim their innocence. Each feels justified in his anger because of the wrongs of the other.
- The household gods (Heb. *teraphim*) were commonly used in divination to consult the will of the gods.
- Rakhel's theft of the household gods parallels Yaaqov's theft of the flocks, both believing that their fertility, security, and future will be provided by taking matters into their own hands.

Lavan Chases and Overtakes Yaaqov

17 And Yaaqov arose and put **his children** and **his wives** upon camels;
18 and he led away all **his livestock**
and all **his property**, which **he** had gathered,
his acquired livestock, which **he** had gathered in Paddan-aram,
to go to Yitskhaq his father, to the land of Canaan.

19 Now, Lavan had gone to shear his flock,
and **Rakhel stole the household idols** that were her father's.
20 And **Yaaqov stole the heart of Lavan** (לב לבן) the Aramean
by **not reporting** to him that he was **fleeing**.

21 And **he fled**, he and **everything that belonged to him**,
and he arose and crossed the river,
and he set his face toward **the hill country of Gilead**.

22 And **it was reported** to Lavan on the third day that Yaaqov **had fled**,
23 and **he took his brothers** with him
and chased after him seven days' journey,
and he clung to (וידבק) him in **the hill country of Gilead**.

24 And **God came to Lavan** the Aramean in a dream **of the night and said to him**,
“**Guard yourself**,
so that you don't speak to Yaaqov either good or evil.”

25 **And Lavan overtook Yaaqov.**

And Yaaqov had pitched his tent in **the hill country** ,
and **Lavan had pitched with his brothers** in **the hill country of Gilead** .

26 And Lavan said to Yaaqov,

“ **What** have you done,
that you should **steal my heart**
and lead away my daughters like captives of the sword?

27 **Why did you** hide yourself to **flee** and **steal me**,
and **did not report to me**
that I might have sent you away with joy and with songs, with timbrel and with lyre;
28 and you did not allow me to kiss **my sons (לבני)** **and my daughters (לבנות)** ?
Now you have acted foolishly.

29 It is in my power to do you **evil** ,
but **the Elohim of your father spoke to me last night, saying**,
‘ **Guard yourself** ,
so as not to speak to Yaaqov either good or evil .’

30 And now, you have indeed gone away,
because you longed greatly for your father’s house;
Why did you **steal my elohim?**”

31 **And Yaaqov replied and he said to Lavan** ,

“Because I was afraid,
for I said, ‘So that you don’t seize your daughters from me!’

32 **With whomever you find your elohim**, that one will not live!
In the presence of our brothers, recognize what is yours from what is with me, and take it! ”
Now, Yaaqov did not know that Rakhel had **stolen them**.

33 And Lavan went into **Yaaqov's** tent
and into **Leah's** tent
and into the tent of **the two maids**,
but he did not find .

And he went out of **Leah's** tent,
and entered **Rakhel's** tent.

34 Now, Rakhel had taken **the household idols**
and she put them in the camel’s saddle,
and she sat on them.
And Lavan felt through all the tent
but he did not find .

35 And she said to her father,
“Don’t let there be **hot-anger** in the eyes of my master,
because I’m not able to rise before you,
for the way of women is upon me.”
And he searched,
but he did not find the household idols.

36 And there was **hot-anger** to Yaaqov,
and **he entered into a contention** with Lavan;

and Yaaqov replied and he said to Lavan,

“What is my transgression?!
What is my sin that you have hotly pursued me?

37 Though you have felt through all **my goods**,
what have you found of all the **goods of your house**?
Place it here in front of my brothers and your brothers,
that they may **act as the mediator** between us two.

38 **These twenty years I was with you ;**
your ewe-lambs (רָחֵל) and your female goats have not miscarried,
nor have I eaten the rams (אֵילִי) of your flocks.

39 That which was torn of beasts, I did not bring to you;
I bore the loss of it myself.
You required it of my hand,
stolen by **day** or **stolen** by **night** .

40 During the **day** I was eaten by the heat,
and by the frost at **night**,
and my sleep fled from my eyes.

41 **These twenty years I have been in your house ;**
I served you four-ten years for your two daughters,
and six years for your flock,
and you changed my wages ten times.

42 **If the God of my father, the God of Abraham, and the fear of Isaac, had not been for me ,**
surely now you would have sent me away empty-handed.
God has seen my affliction and the toil of my hands,
and he **acted as a mediator** last night.”

Genesis 31:17-42. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Ancestral Deception Exposed

In this section, Yaaqov is confronted by Lavan in a way that recalls the earlier stories about Abraham and Yitskhaq's deception of Abimelech.

Yaaqov's Deception	Yitskhaq's Deception	Abraham's Deception
Gen. 29, 31 Yaaqov manipulates Laban's flocks to increase his own and decrease Laban's, after Laban lied about his daughter and "gave" him the wrong wife.	Gen. 26:1-11 Yitskhaq lies to the Philistines and Abimelech about his wife being his sister	Gen. 20 Abraham lies to the Philistines and Abimelech about his wife being his sister
Gen. 31:24 God confronts Laban in "a dream of the night"		Gen. 20:3 God confronts Abimelech in a "dream of the night"
Gen. 31:31 Yaaqov confesses his deception "Because I was afraid (כי יראתי), because I said (כי אמרתי), 'So that you don't steal (פן תגזול) your daughters from me!'"	Gen. 26:7 Yitskhaq's deception "And he said, 'She is my sister,' because he was afraid to say (כי ירא לאמר), 'my wife,' so that 'the men of the place don't murder me (פן יהרגני) on account of Rivqah.'"	Gen. 20:10-11 Abraham's deception "And Abimelech said to Abraham, 'What did you see (ראית), that you have done this thing?' And Abraham said, 'It's because I said (כי אמרתי), 'Surely there is no fear (יראת) of Elohim in this place, so they will murder me on account of my wife.'""
Gen. 30:43 Yaaqov's wealth from his deception "And the man broke out very, very much, and there were for him many flocks and female and male servants and camels and donkeys."	Gen. 26:13-14 Yitskhaq's wealth after his deception "And [Yitskhaq] became great, and continued to grow great, until he became very great; and he had possessions of flocks and herds and a great household"	Gen. 20:14 Abraham's wealth from his deception "And Abimelech took flocks and cattle and slaves and female slaves, and he gave them to Abraham, and he returned to him Sarah his wife."
Yaaqov's Generational Deception. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).		

These intentional comparisons confirm that Yaaqov's strategy with Lavan's flocks was a fear-inspired manipulation, and so was his secretive flight from Lavan's house.

Yaaqov's fear of Lavan is set on analogy with Abraham and Yitskhaq's fear of the Philistines, and his fear represents a lack of trust in Yahweh's promise that "I will be with you."

Yaaqov's Flight and Rakhel's Theft

Notice how Yaaqov and Rakhel's "thefts" are set on close analogy to each other in [Genesis 31:19-30](#).

Genesis 31:19-20 NASB

19

... and Rachel stole the household idols

that were her father's.

20

And Jacob stole the heart of Laban

the Aramean

This tight analogy invites us to ponder all the ways that Yaaqov has "stolen" from Lavan (through manipulation of the flocks, and now by fleeing in secret). But recall that Yaaqov's deceptive theft of Lavan's flocks, and now of his daughters, is a continuation of the ways that Yaaqov had also deceived his own father and brother with food and disguises, all aimed at acquiring the blessing of Eden abundance.

The analogy is brought even closer in the curious scene where Lavan searches and "feels" for his idol gods in the tent. This entire scene is a replay of Yaaqov's deception of his father.

Jacob Deceives His Father	Rachel Deceives Her Father
Gen. 27:8-13 Rebekah proposes the scheme, and invites "the curse" (קללה) to come upon her if Jacob is found out.	Gen. 31:31-32 Jacob proposes the secretive flight, and invokes a curse upon whoever stole the idols: "Whoever is found to have your idol-gods, they will not live!"
Gen. 27:15-16 Jacob dresses up with goat skin	Gen. 31:34 Rachel sits upon the camel-saddle
Gen. 27:21-23 Yitskhaq "feels" (משש) Jacob's arms and doesn't find out his true identity	Gen. 31:34-35 Laban "feels" (משש) through Rachel's tent and doesn't find the idol-gods
Yaaqov's Deception and Rakhel's Theft. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

The network of analogies mutually illuminates the motives of the characters in each case.

- Yaaqov "stole" the blessing from Esau/Yitskhaq in order to gain the abundance of Eden.
- Yaaqov "stole" the flocks of Lavan in order to gain abundance for himself and his family.
- Rakhel "stole" the idol-gods of Lavan in order to gain ... what?

It's surely intentional that we are not told about Rakhel's motives for stealing the idol-gods. We're meant to meditate on the portrait of her character and on the meaning of these analogies to understand her actions. It also helps to know what the *teraphim* actually are!

What Were the Teraphim/Idol-Gods?

Teraphim (Heb. תרפים) are small idol statues that were placed in homes (tents, houses) or in the home of a deity (shrine, temple). A quick survey of the word's usage in the Hebrew Bible shows the role they played in Canaanite and Israelite religion.

2 Kings 23:24 NASB

Moreover, Josiah removed **the mediums and the diviners and the *teraphim* and the idols** and all the abominations that were seen in the land of Judah and in Jerusalem, that he might confirm the words of the law which were written in the book that Hilkiah the priest found in the house of the LORD.

Ezekiel 21:21 NASB

For the king of Babylon stands at the parting of the way, at the head of the two ways, **to use divination; he shakes the arrows, he consults the *teraphim*, he looks at the liver.**

Zechariah 10:2 NASB

For **the *teraphim* speak iniquity, and the diviners see lying visions and tell false dreams;** they comfort in vain. Therefore the people wander like sheep, they are afflicted, because there is no shepherd.

These texts make clear that the *teraphim* were consulted in ritual practices in order to gain information from the gods. This brings to mind one other important moment in the Yaaqov story that brings all the pieces together.

Genesis 30:27-28 Instructor's Translation

And Lavan said to Yaaqov, "If I have found favor in your eyes, **I have learned by divination that Yahweh has blessed me on account of you.** Now then, **mark** your wages and I will give it."

How is it that Lavan "learned by divination" (spelled *nakhash*, same letters as "snake" in Hebrew) that Yaaqov was the source of Yahweh's blessing on his household? The narrative doesn't say in the moment, but delays telling us until Rakhel steals the idol-gods!

Just as Lavan consulted his *teraphim* to discern the source of his abundance in order to gain more, so now his daughter steals the idols in order to do the same. Remember, Rakhel has born only one son in comparison to Leah's six sons and one daughter. And though she said at Joseph's birth, "May Yahweh add to me another son," we now see Rakhel taking her future abundance into her own hands by consulting the *teraphim*. Like father, like daughter, like husband, like son-in-law.

What Lavan, Yaaqov, and Rakhel all share in common is a desire to experience the Eden-blessing and a willingness to do whatever it takes to get it. In Rakhel's case, she justifies stealing her father's source of divination. It helped him identify Yaaqov as the source of blessing, after all. Perhaps it could do the same for her.

Reflection Question

Based on other hints in the surrounding stories, why might Rakhel have stolen the household gods?